

Econ. 623 American Economic History
George Mason University, Fall 2026
Mondays 4:30–7:10
Enterprise Hall (ENT) 274

Instructor: Noel D. Johnson

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Office Location: Buchanan Hall D159

Office Hours: By appointment — email me and we will find a time

Course Webpage: Canvas

Course Description

In this course we will read and discuss a selection of articles about U.S. Economic History. The format of the course is thematic – I will not be teaching the narrative of U.S. history. I place a lot of emphasis on teaching you how to consume cutting-edge empirical research from economics journals. You will also be writing your own research paper. There is no required text and all of the readings are downloadable from the internet.

Course Requirements

Eighty percent of success is showing up – Woody Allen

Hear the words of Snoop Dogg: “[The syllabus, you gotta do it, you gotta read it!](#)”

- Research paper worth 10% of your final grade.
- Research paper presentation worth 30% of your final grade.
- Oral midterm exam worth 30% of your final grade.
- Oral final exam worth 30% of your final grade.

Communication

I will post the syllabus, readings, and announcements to the class web page on Canvas.

Email is the best way to get in touch with me. You can contact me at: njohnsoL@gmu.edu.

Lectures will be in person. However, from time to time it may be convenient for us to communicate using Zoom. Zoom is free. [Follow the instructions at this link to get started.](#)

My personal Zoom meeting room link is:

[Click this link to join zoom meeting](#)

Meeting ID: 912 315 3945

Passcode: 3J5KNG

A Note on the Paper

Your topic can be from any time period before 1960 ('persistence' papers are a partial exception). It need not be related to the economic history of the United States. The paper **should test or attempt to study a specific hypothesis using historical data**. The test need not be econometric. While it is normal to expect that an economics research paper will involve some modeling and simple regressions, it is also possible to produce a good paper making clever use of tables and graphs. What is essential is that you learn how to make an argument and sustain or reject it on the basis of empirical evidence. You might seek to apply an existing model to different data or repeat a test that already exists in the literature using different time periods. The final work should be about 15 pages in length, double-spaced in Times New Roman 12 pt. font.

This class enrolls both master's and Ph.D. students, and the paper is graded to the same standard for everyone. I want a clear question, an empirical argument, and evidence that sustains or rejects it. What differs is scope. If you are a Ph.D. student, I expect you to aim at a question that could plausibly grow into a dissertation chapter or a publishable paper. If you are a master's student, a well-executed test of a narrower hypothesis is exactly right.

The final draft of the paper must be submitted by 11 pm on **December 7th. I will only accept PDFs emailed to me. The subject line of your email should be "AEH Essay" and the file name should be "your last name AEH Essay"**. I will take a letter grade (10%) off your paper grade if you don't submit it when it is due. I will take an additional letter grade (10%) off for every 24-hour period you don't hand it in.

I expect Ph.D. students to write the paper in $\text{\LaTeX}$ (master's students are encouraged, but not required, to do the same). This is the standard among most researchers in economics today and you might as well learn it now rather than later. Here is a source to get you started:

<http://www.maths.tcd.ie/~dwilkins/LaTeXPrimer/>

Here is another one...

<https://www.tug.org/begin.html>

Presentations

Thirty percent of your course grade is determined by your paper presentation.

I encourage the use of slides for your presentation, but try not to overdo it. If you have questions on what is overdoing it, please refer to this book:

- Tufte, E. (1983). *The visual display of quantitative information*. Graphics Press.

I will grade your presentations on “content” (how well you have framed and answered your research question) and “style” (how well you present the material).

Since you’re writing the paper in L^AT_EX, you should probably also make your presentation slides using the L^AT_EX presentation environment known as Beamer. Here are some sample slides and tips on how to make a good presentation:

https://paulgp.github.io/beamer_tips.html

The Oral Exams

There will be two oral exams in this class. The way they will work is that I will distribute a sign-up sheet and you will choose one of the 15-minute time slots. The slots will all be either during our normally scheduled class time (for the midterms) or during our assigned final exam period (for the finals). Then, when that time slot arrives we will meet on Zoom. Before the exam, I will let you all know two or three of the topics I will be asking you about. For example, we will learn the Malthusian Model early in the semester. So, I may tell you that one of the questions I ask you will be about the Malthusian Model. I will then expect you to be able to use the Whiteboard in Zoom to show the model in its initial equilibrium and then to use the model to answer a question like, “What happens in the model when there is a technological innovation?” I guarantee you that at least one of the questions I ask you will be about one of these topics I have told you I will ask about. The exam will almost certainly not take the entire 15 minutes allotted.

I’m requiring you to be either on a laptop or desktop with your camera on for the exam. No phones. This is because you will have to use the Whiteboard functionality of Zoom.

Policy on AI Tools

You may use AI tools at any stage of your work for this class, including the research paper. I use them in my own research and I assume you will use them in yours. Mason gives every student free access to PatriotAI, which provides access to Claude and ChatGPT models in a data-protected environment, so nothing in this class requires a paid subscription. Two conditions apply. First, your paper must include a brief disclosure of how you used these tools, saying what you asked them to do and what you did with the output. Second, when you submit work with your name on it, you are signing every claim in it. You are responsible for verifying that every citation exists, that every number is correct, and that every argument is one you can defend. “The AI wrote that part” is not a defense. The oral exams are where you demonstrate, live, that you understand the material; no tool can sit in that chair for you.

If you want guidance on using these tools well in economic history research, two good places to start are Andreas Ferrara. A practitioner’s guide to using large language models and generative AI in economic history. NBER Working Paper 35374, National Bureau of Economic Research, 2026 and Anton Korinek. Generative AI for economic research: Use cases and implications for economists. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 61(4):1281–1317, 2023.

Recommended Texts

There are no required texts for this class that must be purchased. Most of the readings can be downloaded from JSTOR, the NBER Working Papers archive, EconLit, or the course webpage. You are required to acquire these papers and read them before the week they are listed on the syllabus. You are expected to know the papers on the course reading list for the exams.

In addition to the papers listed in the Course Outline below, you may wish to purchase a general text on U.S. economic history. Good choices would be:

- Jeremy Atack and Peter Passell. *A New Economic View of American History*, (Norton: New York, 1994).
- Jonathan Hughes and Louis Cain. *American Economic History*, (Addison Wesley: 2006).

Also, some of the articles require knowledge of econometric techniques. I will attempt to explain the methods used when they come up; however, this is not an econometrics class and you may wish to have a more detailed treatment of the methods at your disposal. It is a fact of the economist's life that empirical methods are very, very important. Even if you don't plan on using econometrics for your dissertation or in your own research or work, you will look like a fool (and will often be treated like one) if you don't understand the basics. A few excellent sources for the basics (plus some more advanced material) are:

- Joshua Angrist and Jörn-Steffen Pischke, *Mastering Metrics: The Path from Cause to Effect*. (Princeton University Press, 2014).
- Cunningham, S. (2021). *Causal Inference: The Mixtape*. Yale University Press. (A free online edition is available at <https://mixtape.scunning.com>.)
- Huntington-Klein, N. *The Effect: An Introduction to Research Design and Causality*, 2nd edition. Routledge.

A good place to get advice on how to write a paper is D.N. McCloskey. *Economical Writing*. Waveland Press, 2000.

If you are a Ph.D. student I also highly recommend William Thomson, *A Guide for the Young Economist*. (MIT Press: 2011).

Some Important Dates

First Day of Classes: **8/24**

Labor Day (no class): **9/7**

Fall Break (no class): **10/12**

Thanksgiving Recess: **11/25–11/27**

Last Day of Classes: **12/7**

Final Paper Due: **12/7 by 11pm**

Final Exam: **12/14 from 4:30pm to 7:15pm**

PLEASE NOTE: COURSE POLICIES

The four statements below are the University's Common Policy Addendum, which must be made available to students in all Mason courses (Catalog Policy AP.2.5).

1. Academic Standards

Academic Standards exist to promote authentic scholarship, support the institution's goal of maintaining high standards of academic excellence, and encourage continued ethical behavior of faculty and students to cultivate an educational community which values integrity and produces graduates who carry this commitment forward into professional practice. Our standards are upheld in three principles:

- *Honesty*: providing accurate information in all academic endeavors, including communications, assignments, and examinations.
- *Acknowledgement*: giving proper credit for all contributions to one's work, through accurate citations and references for any ideas, words, or materials created by others.
- *Uniqueness of Work*: ensuring that all submitted work is the result of one's own effort and is original, including free from self-plagiarism.

Violations of these standards — including but not limited to plagiarism, fabrication, and cheating — are taken seriously and will be addressed in accordance with university policies. See <https://academicstandards.gmu.edu/>.

Student responsibility: students are responsible for understanding how these general expectations apply to each course, assignment, or exam; ask me for clarification on any aspect that is not clear.

2. Class Registration

Students are responsible for verifying the accuracy of their own schedules. Students need to check PatriotWeb regularly to verify that they are registered for the classes that they think they are. This is particularly important since students are no longer dropped for nonpayment.

Faculty may not allow a student who is not registered to continue to attend class and may not grade the work of students who do not appear on the official class roster.

Deadlines each semester are published in the Schedule of Classes, available from the Registrar's website: <https://registrar.gmu.edu>.

After the last day to drop a class, withdrawing from this class requires the approval of the dean and is only allowed for nonacademic reasons.

3. Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

Disability Services at George Mason University is committed to upholding the letter and spirit of the laws that ensure equal treatment of people with disabilities. Under the administration of University Life, Disability Services implements and coordinates reasonable accommodations and disability-related services that afford equal access to university programs and activities. Students can begin the registration process with Disability Services at any time during their enrollment. If you are seeking accommodations, please visit <https://ds.gmu.edu/> for detailed information about

the registration process. Disability Services is located in Student Union Building I (SUB I), Suite 2500. Email: ods@gmu.edu. Phone: (703) 993-2474.

Student responsibility: students are responsible for registering with Disability Services and communicating about their approved accommodations with me in advance of any relevant class meeting, assignment, or exam.

4. FERPA and Use of Mason Email Addresses for Course Communication

The Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) governs the disclosure of education records for eligible students and is an essential aspect of any course. Students must use their Mason email account to receive important University information, including communications related to this class. Instructors will not respond to messages sent from, or send messages regarding course content to, a non-Mason email address.

Student responsibility: students are responsible for checking their Mason email regularly for course-related information, or ensuring that Mason email messages are forwarded to an account they do check.

5. Title IX Resources and Required Reporting

As a part of George Mason University's commitment to providing a safe and non-discriminatory learning, living, and working environment for all members of the University community, the University does not discriminate on the basis of sex or gender in any of its education or employment programs and activities. Accordingly, all non-confidential employees, including your faculty member, have a legal requirement to report to the Title IX Coordinator all relevant details obtained directly or indirectly about any incident of Prohibited Conduct (such as sexual harassment, sexual assault, gender-based stalking, dating/domestic violence). Upon notifying the Title IX Coordinator of possible Prohibited Conduct, the Title IX Coordinator will assess the report and determine if outreach is required. If outreach is required, the individual the report is about (the "Complainant") will receive a communication, likely in the form of an email, offering that person the option to meet with a representative of the Title IX office.

For more information about non-confidential employees, resources, and Prohibited Conduct, please see University Policy 1202: *Sexual and Gender-Based Misconduct and Other Forms of Interpersonal Violence*. Questions regarding Title IX can be directed to the Title IX Coordinator via email to TitleIX@gmu.edu, by phone at 703-993-8730, or in person on the Fairfax campus in Aquia 373.

Student opportunity: if you prefer to speak to someone confidentially, please contact one of Mason's confidential employees in Student Support and Advocacy (SSAC), Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS), Student Health Services (SHS), or the Office of the University Ombudsperson.

Course Outline

Week 1 (8/24): Introduction

- Pep talk on research from David Weil
- Chapter 1 in Jeremy Atack and Peter Passell. A new economic view of american history: From colonial times to 1940, 1994
- Paul M Romer. Why, indeed, in america? theory, history, and the origins of modern economic growth. *American Economic Review*, 86(2):202–206, 1996
- Nathan Nunn. The historical roots of economic development. *Science*, 367(6485), 2020
- Chapter 2, “The Logic of the Malthusian Economy,” in Gregory Clark. *A Farewell to Alms: A Brief Economic History of the World*. Princeton University Press, 2007
- Section I (pp. 685–687) and Figure I (p. 682) of Michael Kremer. Population growth and technological change: One million B.C. to 1990. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 108(3):681–716, 1993

Week 2 (8/31): Measurement and Causality

- Pages 291–300 of David A Freedman. Statistical models and shoe leather. *Sociological methodology*, pages 291–313, 1991
- Bellemare, “A Primer on Linear Regression”
- Bellemare, “A Primer on Causality”

Week 3 (9/14): Colonialism as a Natural Experiment

- Daron Acemoglu, Simon Johnson, and James A Robinson. The colonial origins of comparative development: An empirical investigation. *American economic review*, 91(5):1369–1401, 2001
- Melissa Dell. The persistent effects of peru’s mining mita. *Econometrica*, 78(6):1863–1903, 2010
- Timothy G. Conley and Morgan Kelly. The standard errors of persistence. *Journal of International Economics*, 153:104027, 2025

Week 4 (9/21): Institutions, Culture, and Antecedents

- Federalist No. 10. Alexander Hamilton, James Madison, and John Jay. The Federalist Papers. Any edition, any publisher.
- Noel D. Johnson and Mark Koyama. States and economic growth: Capacity and constraints. *Explorations in Economic History*, 64:1–20, 2017
- Naomi R Lamoreaux. The mystery of property rights: A us perspective. *The Journal of Economic History*, pages 275–306, 2011

- Samuel Bazzi, Martin Fiszbein, and Mesay Gebresilasie. Frontier culture: The roots and persistence of “rugged individualism” in the United States. *Econometrica*, 88(6):2329–2368, 2020

Week 5 (9/28): Industrialization

- Robert C Allen. Why the industrial revolution was british: commerce, induced invention, and the scientific revolution 1. *The Economic History Review*, 64(2):357–384, 2011
- Gregory Clark. Why isn’t the whole world developed? lessons from the cotton mills. *Journal of Economic History*, 47(1):141–173, 1987
- W. Walker Hanlon. Necessity is the mother of invention: Input supplies and directed technical change. *Econometrica*, 83(1):67–100, 2015

Week 6 (10/5): Cities

- Donald R Davis and David E Weinstein. Bones, bombs, and break points: the geography of economic activity. *American Economic Review*, 92(5):1269–1289, 2002
- Hoyt Bleakley and Jeffrey Lin. Portage and path dependence. *The quarterly journal of economics*, 127(2):587–644, 2012

Week 7 (10/19): Oral Midterm Exams

Week 8 (10/26): Health & Disease

- Preface and Introduction from Werner Troesken. *The pox of liberty: how the constitution left Americans rich, free, and prone to infection*. University of Chicago Press, 2015
- Joseph P Ferrie and Werner Troesken. Water and chicago’s mortality transition, 1850–1925. *Explorations in Economic History*, 45(1):1–16, 2008
- Marcella Alsan and Marianne Wanamaker. Tuskegee and the health of black men. *The quarterly journal of economics*, 133(1):407–455, 2018

Week 9 (11/2): Infrastructure

- Richard Hornbeck and Daniel Keniston. Creative destruction: Barriers to urban growth and the great boston fire of 1872. *American Economic Review*, 107(6):1365–1398, 2017
- Richard Hornbeck and Martin Rotemberg. Growth off the rails: Aggregate productivity growth in distorted economies. *Journal of Political Economy*, 132(11):3547–3602, 2024

Week 10 (11/9): The Legacy of Slavery

- Gavin Wright. The civil rights revolution as economic history. *The Journal of Economic History*, 59(2):267–289, 1999

- Lukas Althoff and Hugo Reichardt. Jim crow and black economic progress after slavery. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 139(4):2279–2330, 2024
- Ran Abramitzky, Leah Boustan, Katherine Eriksson, James Feigenbaum, and Santiago Pérez. Automated linking of historical data. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 59(3):865–918, 2021

Week 11 (11/16): The Great Depression

- Price Fishback. Us monetary and fiscal policy in the 1930s. *Oxford Review of Economic Policy*, 26(3):385–413, 2010
- Christina D Romer. The great crash and the onset of the great depression. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 105(3):597–624, 1990
- Gary Richardson and William Troost. Monetary intervention mitigated banking panics during the great depression: quasi-experimental evidence from a federal reserve district border, 1929–1933. *Journal of Political Economy*, 117(6):1031–1073, 2009

Week 12 (11/23): Recent Developments

- Nicholas Bloom, Charles I Jones, John Van Reenen, and Michael Webb. Are ideas getting harder to find? *American Economic Review*, 110(4):1104–44, 2020
- Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li, and Lindsey Raymond. Generative AI at work. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 140(2):889–942, 2025
- Charles I. Jones. AI and our economic future. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 40(3):3–22, 2026

Week 13 (11/30): Student Paper Presentations

Week 14 (12/7): Student Paper Presentations

12/14 from 4:30pm to 7:15pm: Final Oral Exams